

For C

Hi.

Hello.

Nice to meet you.

Let's be friends.

You remind me of someone

I know

I've known before

but

can't

quite

place

from

when.

Maybe

it's my friend from the old country?

The one I made the crossing with

but never saw again?

Or

is it my midwife?

Or

the queen I once served?

No.

I think it's my best friend-

the little girl I played pretend with,

who was motherless like me,

whose lunch I packed
while she packed mine,
Then we taught ourselves to be pretty,
to wear makeup,
to buy bras,
and steeled ourselves
so we'd be ready
to help our real moms stop crying
if they ever got up off the floor.

You remind me of

the Blazing Star
I shared a wordless conversation with
once:
before we had bodies,
when we were only light.
Making plans.
Agreements.
"I'll meet you there."

Wait.

I think it's the orca I swam beside for years
raised together in the icy water.
We shared currents,
borrowing each other's momentum,
till we became the matriarchs
and the pod was ours to guide.

You do remind me of

the girl I hated in 5th grade.
The bossy one I could never compete with
with better roller skates
and older friends.

Or it could be

the girl I stood with

in a tiny church
outside Alamogordo
flanking our friend,
the teenage bride.
There to witness
the beginning of the end.
That entire wedding party was too young to vote!
And we all stood a little too close to the altar
our hairspray-laden updos
starting to smoke
the closer we got to the
flames.

Or maybe

it's the one I cried with
when we realized
our childhoods had ended.
The one I plotted with *because*
our childhoods had ended.

You remind me of

the friend
who lived in the house
where I had my first kiss.

No!

You look just like the monk I saw once
in the courtyard of a mountain-top temple
wrapped in an orange robe,
clouds crowning
her freshly shaved head,
eyes filled with a world
we had yet to behold.

Or maybe

you remind me of the wave that formed

next to me
even as I was forming:
two distinct moments
inside the same sea.

You remind me of

a roommate I had once.
The one
I tormented
nightly
with my band practice.
The one
I held tight
as we hurled ourselves
into adulthood.

Or

the one who was waiting up for me
when I came home in the middle of the night
drunk on oxytocin
and beer
neck rubbed raw
from my new boyfriend's stubble,
the one I'd marry 8 months later that year.

Nevermind.

You remind me of a woman
I knew when our boys were tiny.
We would talk for hours on the couch
about how to keep our babies alive,
how exhausted we were,
how much we loved them,
how we couldn't remember life
before them.
How we knew our lives were too small
but it was ok-
mostly because

it had to be.

No, I know.

You were the one
I met in the dark forest.
A fellow witch
combing the underbrush, rivers, and streams
outrunning the soldiers,
dodging the priests,
gathering medicine
so our people could see.

Or maybe

it's the woman in the restaurant.
The one who saved my life with
a dinner knife and
a swift cut to the trachea.
Unmedicated,
Brave Love.
Something was stuck and I was choking to death.
So she cut.
Decisive,
even though I know her hands were shaking.
And it hurt like hell but I did not die.
I am here to tell the tale
so much more alive
than I ever was before.

You remind me of

the
woman
who
jumped
first.
The one who capsized the boat
and swam for her life,
eyes fixed

unflinchingly
forward.
Always forward.
Never back.
The one
who strapped herself into a
rocket
and
flew
until all that remained
was a faint glow,
the soft outline a space
she'd once inhabited.

Or maybe

you remind me
of the woman I knew last fall.
The one who rebuilt her entire life
from the grit beneath her nails.
She made it look like
sorcery,
forming a new world
from nothing but dust.
Assembling and animating it
with only her breath,
her trust.
But I heard her crying in the RV at night.
And I knew
it was all too immense
to defile with words,
and she'd asked for her privacy,
and the pain was hers not mine,
so I cried
and cried
with her each day
standing just outside.

No.

It's definitely Joan of Arc.
who reminds me of you!

The one who liberated herself and showed me how.
The one who couldn't wait for me
but never stopped leaving signs,
dropping feathers,
snapping twigs,
always hoping we would meet again
a little way down the road.

By Abby Buchanan (2024)